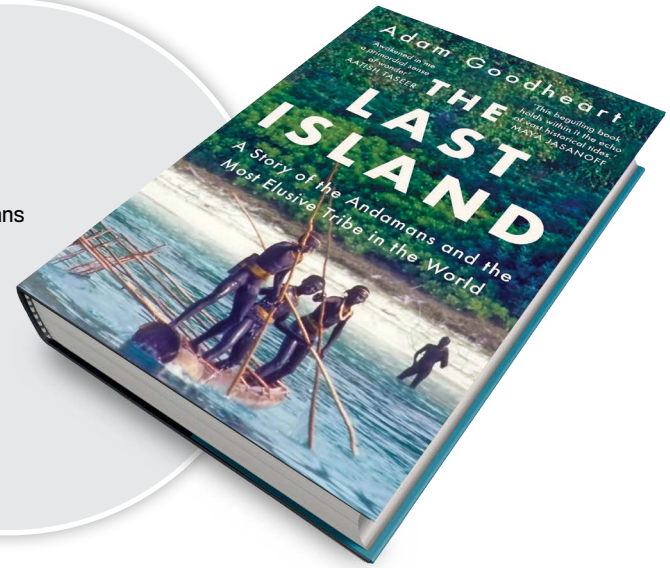


THE LAST ISLAND
A Story of the Andamans and the Most Elusive Tribe in the World
By Adam Goodheart
JUGGERNAUT
₹**699; 256** pages

BOOKS

SAVAGING THE CIVILISED

Adam Goodheart's *The Last Island* is a fascinating and heartbreaking account of the Andaman encounter with the outside world

In early 2019, I was on a plane descending into Port Blair when the pilot came on the PA system to say passengers might want to check out the island to our left—North Sentinel. For those who had missed the breathless news coverage, he explained that an American missionary had been killed there recently by the islanders, an isolated tribe that wanted to stay that way.

Travel writer and historian Adam Goodheart's fascination with North Sentinel started before this latest flurry of attention. In 1998, he read an article about an Indian anthropologist's friendly interaction with the Sentinelese and felt he had to try to go there. The only problem was that this island was somewhat inaccessible. In the first section of *The Last Island*, Goodheart recounts his trip to the Andamans from the US and how he paid fishermen to sneak him up close to the island for a view. He writes in the book: "At times, I have felt more like an astronomer, straining for signals from a familiar-yet-distant planet; even my close encounter with the island's sandy shore was an orbit rather than a landing."

If the travel writer is somewhat thwarted, the historian in Goodheart roots through archives in Delhi, Kolkata and London and finds more than enough material. *The Last Island* becomes a fascinating and heartbreaking account of the Andaman encounter with outsiders since the arrival of the British. It's giving nothing away to say that the peoples of the islands were savaged in more ways than one and nearly wiped out. A particularly rich source in Goodheart's account is Maurice Vidal Portman's personal diary, which lay misclassified in the rare books section of the British Library, until Goodheart chanced upon it. Portman was a late-19th-century British administrator and one of the most prolific colonial documenters of the islands. The only known photographs taken on North Sentinel are his. And it is possible that it was his abduction of a few islanders that turned them against outsiders.

Goodheart's two trips to the islands, his interviews with anthropologists, journalists, government officials and the occasional meeting with Jarawa tribesmen give his account a rich texture. His writing is refreshingly sober on a subject that is often exoticised. It's also self-aware: Goodheart wonders if he and the would-be missionary John Chau are all that different from other illicit seafarers in the Andamans. After all, weren't they both, in a way, "poachers [...] of experiences, glimmers of the sublime"?

As the Age of Discovery draws to a close and the world deals with its consequences, *The Last Island* sees North Sentinel as the lone holdout on a dizzyingly interconnected planet. In a sense, the book is a meditation on what it means to be civilised, to acknowledge the humanity of those who live differently. Despite several 'contact missions' and a survey party in 1970 that Goodheart tells us scooted after erecting a stone edict that declared their island part of the Republic of India, the Sentinelese have chosen to keep to themselves. Maybe one day they will relent and tell us what they think about the rest of the world. Until then, we will look on from boats and planes and wonder. ■

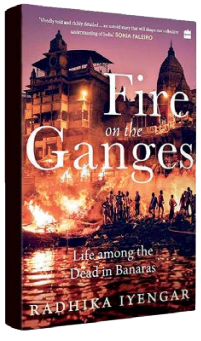
Srinath Perur

Crazy but wonderful, this superbly written and often hilarious account of how the West sought enlightenment from the East—enabling the East to cash in on the gullibility of Uncle Sam—tracks how from inspired literary beginnings, the quest for wisdom was sidetracked by what the Beat poet Allen Ginsberg called "professional lunatic saints".

Edwin Arnold's epic poem, *The Light of Asia*, extolled the nobility of the Buddha's life, while Paul Brunton's *A Search in Secret India* through Ramana Maharshi demonstrated to the sad Saxon soul the lineaments of divine immanence. Thereafter, the graph of spiritual understanding, as this account of crazy but captivating holy personages shows, would shoot up in purple promise only

Circle of Life

In *Fire on the Ganges*, **Radhika Iyengar** trains her journalistic eye on the Doms, the sect responsible for the cremation of Hindus in Varanasi



FIRE ON THE GANGES
Life Among the Dead in Banaras
By Radhika Iyengar
HARPERCOLLINS
₹**599; 352** pages